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Intensive versus extensive reading

How are the two different and why both approaches need to complement each other to encourage students to read

K. Elango

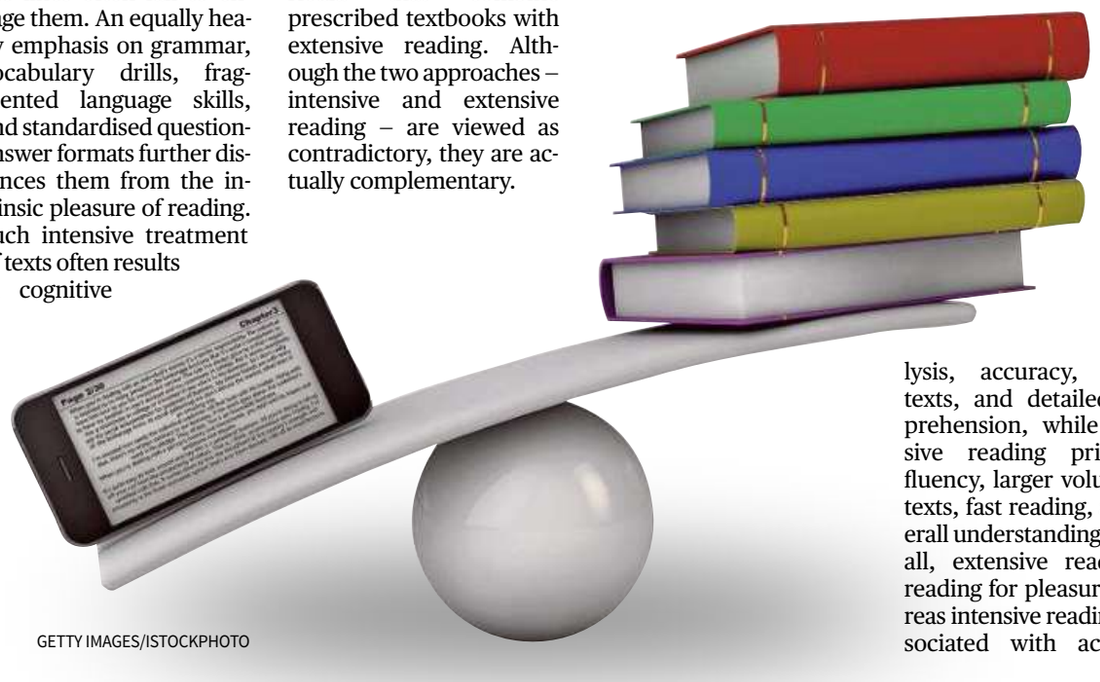
Academia is in a 'reading crisis', increasingly perplexed by a persistent question: how can students be persuaded to read, including their own textbooks? The common allegations – excessive screen time, dopamine-driven digital addiction, shrinking attention spans, a craving for constant stimulation, complex grammatical structures, and dated linguistic expressions – are unquestioningly valid, but do not show a trajectory for restoring students' interest in reading.

Two approaches

Digital natives, paradoxically, read constantly, often, far more than previous generations. From their birth, they are exposed to screens (big and small) that have made reading almost as natural as fish take to water. Digital platforms offer far more convenience, including customisable fonts that reduce visual fatigue and encourage sustained reading; backlit screens enable reading even in darkness; hyperlinks provide instant access to dictionaries, translations, and reference materials; and annotation and highlighting tools make revisions far more efficient. Consequently, students experience reading as an interactive, personalised, and highly responsive activity. They consider reading to be cool.

This experience turns topsy-turvy when students enter classrooms with their school bags: traditional textbook- and teacher-centric instruction transports them into an insipid world. The prescribed iconic writers and the iconic pieces, ironically, bear little resemblance to their lived experiences. Pedagogical practices that rely heavily on line-by-line explanation, close textual analysis, and interpretation between and beyond the lines often fail to engage them. An equally heavy emphasis on grammar, vocabulary drills, fragmented language skills, and standardised question-answer formats further distances them from the intrinsic pleasure of reading. Such intensive treatment of texts often results in cognitive fatigue, making meaningful reading a casualty. Incidentally, it is quite contrary to the way grown-ups engage with reading after school.

Many learners remark that a dissected approach to texts robs them of the joy of reading. Specialists consider such practices to undermine the fundamental objective of education: nurturing autonomous, lifelong readers. Consequently, they advocate curricula that combine prescribed textbooks with extensive reading. Although the two approaches – intensive and extensive reading – are viewed as contradictory, they are actually complementary.



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Both are necessary

Intensive reading involves a close examination of a relatively small number of texts, requiring learners to analyse explicit and implicit meanings, figurative language, syntactic features, intra- and inter-textual relationships and varying critical perspectives. It resembles almost a dissection in a biology lab. Undoubtedly cognitively demanding, academia continues to rely heavily on this approach, with literary studies representing its peak.

Extensive reading, conversely, is reading whatever one is interested in, obviously varying from person to person, ranging from periodicals (newspapers, magazines, journals) to multiple genres of fiction and non-fiction, such as sci-fi, romance novels, autobiographies, travelogues, and so forth. Reflecting on his childhood, Shashi Tharoor remarked that he read "eclectically and indiscriminately", ranging from children's books to classics. Such freedom of choice is sure to cultivate lifelong reading habits among many.

The distinctions between the two approaches are self-evident: intensive reading emphasises features such as in-depth analysis, accuracy, limited texts, and detailed comprehension, while extensive reading prioritises fluency, larger volumes of texts, fast reading, and overall understanding. Above all, extensive reading is reading for pleasure, whereas intensive reading is associated with academic obligation. An effective curriculum requires both approaches to work in tandem rather than in competition.

Recognising the criticality of extensive reading, countries such as Japan, Indonesia, and Italy have established professional associations dedicated to promoting it. These organisations encourage learners to read widely for pleasure and fluency, and support teachers by publishing journals and organising conferences and workshops that foster a vibrant reading culture. In India, the English Language Teachers' Association of India (ELTAI) has launched a student-led, pan-India reading movement to cultivate reading for pleasure and nurture lifelong readers.

Similarly, the debate between e-reading and print reading (p-reading) should not be considered an either-or choice. Learners, particularly in the foundational years, must become amphibious readers, moving effortlessly between digital platforms and printed books. Such balanced engagement will ensure that the art of reading thrives in the era of AI when the 'death of reading' is predicted. Natural intelligence can be developed by reading. A nation that reads is a nation that leads.

The writer is a retired Professor of English, Anna University, and Chief Executive Chair of English Language Teachers' Association of India (ELTAI).

SCHOLARSHIPS

SML Mahindra Scholarship
An initiative of SML Mahindra Limited.
Eligibility: Open to daughters of drivers of heavy and light commercial road transport vehicles, who are studying in Classes 11 or 12 or pursuing UG, diploma or polytechnic courses in STEM and core Engineering fields with minimum 60% and family income of ₹600,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹30,000
Application: Online
Deadline: October 21
www.b4s.in/edge/SMLS1

Parivartan ECSS Programme
An initiative of the HDFC Bank
Eligibility: Students who are Indian nationals studying in school (Class 1 to 12) or in diploma, ITI, polytechnic, UG and PG (general and professional) courses and have minimum 55% in the most recent qualifying exam and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹250,000. Preference will be given to those who have experienced a personal/family crisis in the past three years that impacted their ability to continue their studies.
Rewards: Up to ₹75,000
Application: Online
Deadline: October 31
www.b4s.in/edge/HDFC63

NSP Post-Matric Financial Assistance Scheme
Offered by the Ministry of Labour and Employment, Government of India.
Eligibility: Wards of workers *beedi*, cine, IOMC, LSDM, or mica mine industries who are students in a government-recognised institution (from Class 11 to PG) and have passed the previous qualifying exam in the first attempt. Monthly income should not exceed ₹10,000 (*beedi*/mine industries) and ₹8,000 (cine workers).
Rewards: Up to ₹25,000 per annum.
Application: Online
Deadline: October 31
www.b4s.in/edge/MLE9

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Anandi Fellowship

Bombay Shaving Company invites applications for the Anandi Fellowship, which aims to identify entrepreneurial talent among young Indians through the Anandi-NEAT (Nationwide Entrepreneurship Acumen Test) 2026.
Eligibility: Students in Class 11 and 12, or in the first year of UG programmes. No start-up, prototype, or prior experience is required to register.
Deadline: October 15, 2026
For details, visit tinyurl.com/56w36f6c



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

Identify a mentor

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

I have completed my UG degree and have a strong desire to clear the TNPSC exam, but feel lazy and demotivated. How can I build a consistent study habit? Nithiyasri

Dear Nithiyasri,

Are you sure you are not overwhelmed by the massive syllabus? First, confirm that you have the official TNPSC syllabus (Group 1, 2, or 4, based on your target) and skim the broad subject heads (General Tamil/English, Indian Polity, Aptitude). Then collect Samacheer Kalvi textbooks (classes 6 to 10). These are easier to digest than advanced competitive exam guides.

Commit to studying for 15-20 minutes in a one-hour block. Pick the easiest or most interesting topic and slowly build the discipline to work through multiple hourly blocks and increase the study time. Start with 3-4 cycles a day and increase as you feel more confident. Habit stacking will help with consistency.

Pair your study session with a habit that you already enjoy. Mark detailed portions on a calendar — weekly, fortnightly, monthly — and measure your progress. Start solving old question papers. If you still do not make progress, identify a mentor and work with someone you respect and can be accountable to.

I am in the final year of Medicine but don't want to be a physician. While preparing for the UPSC, I realised that I love studying Economics. Will I be able to pursue a Master's in Economics? Name withheld

Transitioning from Medicine to a Master's in Economics is possible, but before making any drastic changes, think through your decision. Economics in the UPSC General Studies focuses heavily on policy intuition, macro-trends, inflation, public finance, and descriptive analysis, whereas graduate-level Economics is predominantly Applied Maths and Quantitative Modelling.

Test your comfort with formal quantitative economics: multivariable calculus, linear algebra, and probability/statistics. *Intermediate Microeconomics* by Hal Varian is the standard undergraduate textbook. If you enjoy the mathematical formulations of consumer choice and optimisation in this, you will thrive in an MA/M.Sc. Economics environment.
While an MBBS degree is a recognised Bachelor's degree, verify specific prerequisite course requirements for each institution. Programmes at Delhi School of Economics, ISI, IGIDR, or MSE usually mandate calculus, linear algebra, and statistics at the UG level or require competitive entrance exams like CUET-PG (Economics) or IIT-JAM (Economics). Universities abroad offer Conversion Master's in Economics or M.Sc. Economics tracks for non-Economics graduates with strong quantitative skills.

I'm doing B. Pharm, but I wish to go into banking solely for financial security. How can I make the switch? Reeva

Dear Reeva,

All major bank recruitment exams (IBPS PO, IBPS Clerk, SBI PO, RBI Assistant) require a recognised Bachelor's degree in any discipline. Start looking at the key notifications and prepare for these exams. You will need to master Quantitative Aptitude (Data Interpretation, Simplification), Logical Reasoning, English, and General Awareness tests.

You could also leverage your Pharma background and target specialised roles like IBPS Specialist Officer (SO) or Agriculture Field Officer (AFO) if eligible, or look for Credit Analyst or Technical Officer roles in commercial banks that evaluate healthcare and pharmaceutical business loans. Consider PG Diplomas in Banking as an alternative route for private banks. ICICI Manipal Probationary Officers Programme or HDFC Future Bankers train non-commerce graduates and guarantee placement.

Public Sector Banks come with an unmatched job security, standardised pay scales, allowances, and medical benefits. But there is high pressure to meet business targets, potential rural postings, and high entry competition. In comparison, Private Banks have a faster hiring process and quicker merit-based promotions but without job security. If financial stability is your primary goal, look at pharma-adjacent roles like Pharma Data Analytics, Regulatory Affairs, or Medical Writing. These provide higher entry pay and stronger work-life balance than entry-level private banking.

I am in the second year of B.Tech. Dairy Technology. I want to do a Master's in this field. What skills should I develop? Is it possible to work part-time alongside B.Tech? Rishad

Dear Rishad,

Focus on advanced quality assurance and microbiological testing techniques and chemical analysis, dairy process engineering and unit operations, HTST plants, spray drying, membrane filtration and homogenisation, and food safety management systems.

Acquire certifications with conceptual clarity in HACCP, ISO 22000, and FSSAI regulations. Learn Modern Research and data skills and tools like R, SPSS, or Python for statistical quality control, analysis of variance (ANOVA), and response surface methodology (RSM). Build familiarity with analytical instruments like HPLC, Gas Chromatography (GC), Spectrophotometry, and Rheometers.

Part-time jobs may be difficult due to the rigorous, lab-heavy nature of your course. However, flexible remote or project-based work is possible. Consider tutoring for school-level Chemistry, Biology, or basic Maths on ed-tech platforms; explore technical writing or content development for food safety blogs, agritech startups, or educational portals; or assist researchers with literature reviews or statistical data entry remotely. Approach your professors for research assistantships that contribute directly to your Master's application through research publications, conference papers, and strong letters of recommendation (LORs).

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

When knowledge keep evolving

Why research literacy matters in medical education

Dr. Sweta Sahu

Medicine is one of the few professions in which learning never truly ends. New studies are published every day, clinical guidelines evolve, and treatments once considered the standard of care may be replaced as stronger evidence emerges. In such a rapidly changing field, medical students must not only understand what the current evidence recommends, but also how it was generated, how reliable it is, and how it should be applied to individual patients. This ability is known as research literacy. Just as important is knowing when to begin developing it. The answer is: much earlier than most students realise.

Core clinical skill

Research literacy is the ability to read and understand scientific literature, interpret study findings, recognise potential bias, and judge whether the evidence is strong enough to guide patient care. A research-literate physician does not simply accept a study's conclusion but asks: Was the study well designed? Was the sample representative? Were the outcomes clinically meaningful? Are the findings applicable to the patient in front of me? These are central to evidence-based medicine.

Yet many students receive limited practical training in critically appraising scientific literature. Medical education often remains heavily focused on textbooks, examinations, and the retention of established facts. Although this foundation is essential, it may not adequately prepare students to evaluate conflicting evidence, identify methodological limitations, or understand why recommendations change over time.

As medicine becomes increasingly evidence-driven, the ability to assess research is no longer an optional academic skill. It is an essential part of clinical competence. Many medical students view research primarily as something to pursue before residency applications or postgraduate training. This often leads them to begin under pressure, with limited time to understand the research process meaningfully.



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Why start early

Starting early allows students to learn without being driven by deadlines, publications, or application requirements. Whether they participate in a case report, literature review, survey, retrospective study, or clinical audit, students gradually learn how to formulate a research question, search the literature, assess existing evidence, organise data, interpret findings, and communicate scientific conclusions. Early involvement also gives students the freedom to make mistakes, ask basic questions, and develop their interests over time.

Most importantly, research nurtures critical thinking. Students begin to move beyond asking, "What is the recommended treatment?" and start asking, "Why is this treatment recommended? What evidence supports it? How strong is that evidence? Could new findings change current practice?" This strengthens both academic understanding and future clinical decision-making and connects classroom knowledge with real clinical questions.

Consider hypertension. A student may initially focus on blood-pressure thresholds, medication classes, and treatment targets. Research literacy encourages deeper exploration: How were these thresholds determined? Which patient populations were included in the major trials? What outcomes improved? Do the same recommendations apply to older adults, pregnant patients, or people with multiple co-morbidities? This transforms learning from passive memorisation into active inquiry and prepares students for a career in which knowledge will continually evolve. A physician cannot rely indefinitely on what was taught during medical school but must be able to evaluate new evidence throughout their professional life.

How to start

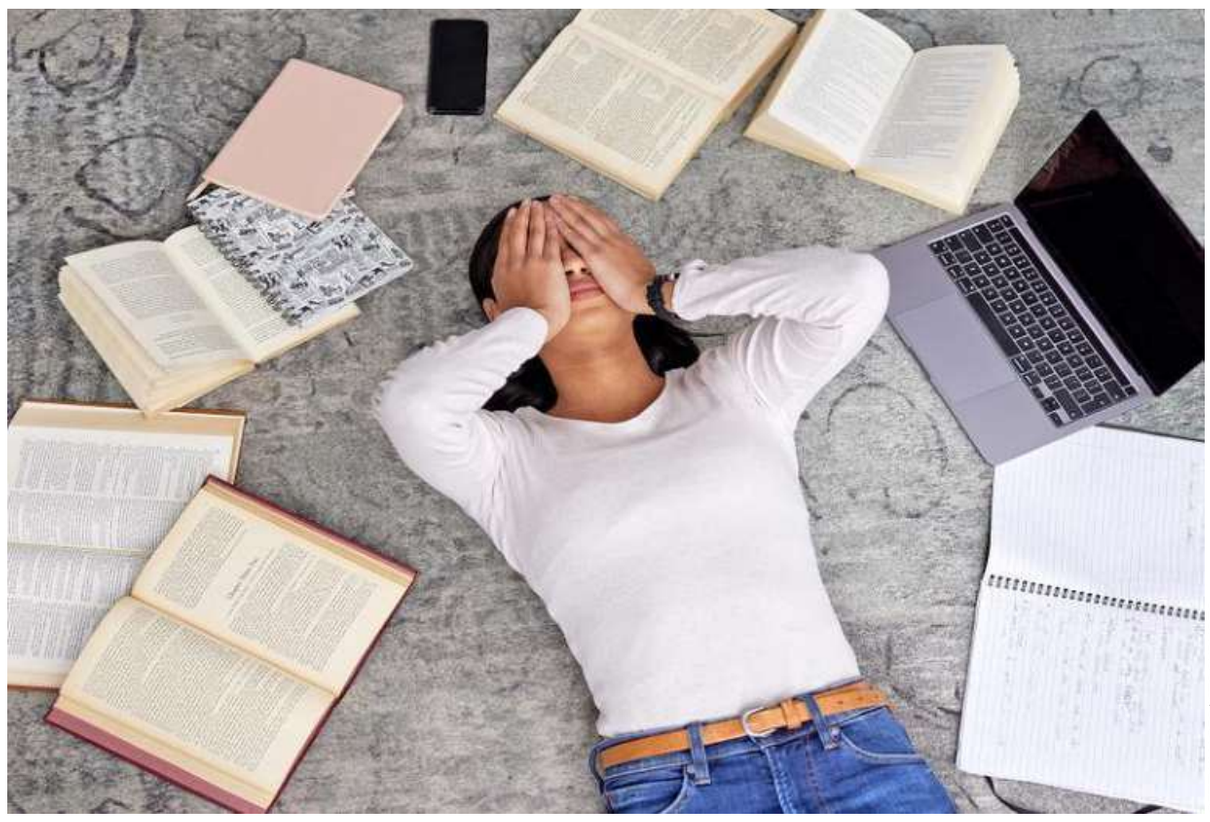
Beginning research does not require access to an advanced laboratory or a large clinical trial. In fact, smaller and well-supervised projects are often the most effective place to start. Case reports, literature reviews, journal clubs, clinical audits, retrospective chart reviews, and faculty-guided surveys can introduce students to the fundamentals of scientific inquiry.

The quality of mentorship also matters. An accessible mentor who explains the process, provides constructive feedback, and encourages independent thinking may offer a more valuable learning experience than a renowned researcher who has little time to teach. Students should also resist viewing research solely as a way to strengthen their curriculum vitae. Publications and presentations can be valuable outcomes, but the deeper goal is to develop the confidence to question, analyse, and apply evidence responsibly.

Medical schools can integrate these skills into the curriculum through structured teaching in study design, biostatistics, literature appraisal, scientific writing, and evidence-based medicine. Journal clubs, mentored projects, research electives, and opportunities to present findings can further help students translate theoretical knowledge into practical ability. Research exposure should also be made accessible to students with different levels of experience. Not every student will become a clinician-scientist, but future doctors will need to interpret scientific evidence, as they will practise in a healthcare environment shaped by continuous scientific discovery.

When these skills are developed from the beginning, students become more thoughtful learners, more discerning consumers of scientific information, and ultimately more capable clinicians.

The writer is a physician in Healthy Ageing and Preventive Brain Health and the founder of ActiveMind Daily and MedResearch Ninja.



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The first-year reset

Why high-achieving students can struggle in college and why universities need to teach them new ways of learning

Siddharth Rajgarhia

She topped her board exams and cleared a brutal entrance test that thousands failed. By every measure the system uses, she was ready. Six weeks into university, she was sitting in a counsellor's office, certain she did not belong there.

This story repeats itself across the country every year, and we keep misreading it. We call it stress, homesickness, or the pressure of a tougher syllabus. Occasionally, we blame the student. We rarely name the real cause: the way these students learnt to win in school is exactly what is failing them in college. Nobody warned them it would.

For over a decade, schools trained students to optimise for one thing: the exam. Coaching factories, model answers, and relentless drilling produce high scorers. But they also produce a particular kind of learner: one who waits to be told what matters, memorises it, and reproduces it on demand. In a high-stakes, exam-driven system, that is a perfectly rational strategy. The trouble is that university runs on the opposite logic. It rewards curiosity and comfort with ambiguity, independent reading, and the slow, frustrating work of building understanding for yourself. The first year is often when old habits stop working. No one taught these students new ones.

How to learn

This is why universities need to treat the first year as a deliberate reset. The quiet assumption that students already 'know how to learn' is its most damaging blind spot. Students are expected to absorb academic skills by osmosis while adjusting to a new city, sudden freedom, and unfamiliar social pressure. Some manage. Many don't. We mistake their struggle for weakness, when it is really a skills gap we never bothered to close.

So, what would teaching students how to learn look like? It starts with making the invisible visible. Skilled learning involves habits that often go untaught because they happen invisibly. The learner questions a source instead of swallowing it, links a new idea to something already understood, tests understanding before an exam does, and spaces study instead of cramming the night before.

A landmark review by Dunlosky and colleagues in *Psychological Science in the Public Interest* found that two of the most effective study techniques – practice testing and spaced repetition – are among the least used by students. A first-year curriculum could build better habits through short, practical work on critical reading, structured note-making, retrieval practice, and managing one's own attention. This evidence has existed for over a decade. Students seldom get told.

It also means changing how we treat failure. A student who fails her first university assignment is meeting the gap between school's certainty and college's open-endedness for the first time. Treated as a verdict, that moment breeds anxiety and quiet withdrawal. Treated as information – here is what your current approach misses, here is how to fix it – it becomes the engine of everything that follows.

Carol Dweck's research on mindset makes the point that students who see ability as fixed tend to crumble when they stumble, while those who see it as something they can grow treat setbacks as a cue to change their approach. Universities that build in low-stakes early feedback – where being wrong costs little and teaches a lot – give students the room to relearn how to learn.

Hopeful signs

None of this is about softening standards or coddling. It is about honesty. We have spent years complaining that graduates cannot think analytically, cannot write, cannot learn on their own. But we have not helped students grow those abilities. The first year is the natural place to intervene because the habits formed there tend to last the whole degree.

There are hopeful signs. Some institutions now run foundation courses and learning-skills workshops. The National Education Policy at least gestures toward critical thinking and flexible, multidisciplinary study. But too often these efforts are bolted on as orientation-week theatre rather than woven into how subjects are taught. A reset cannot be a one-week event. It has to live in everyday teaching, in a chemistry lecturer or a literature professor showing students how an expert in their field actually thinks.

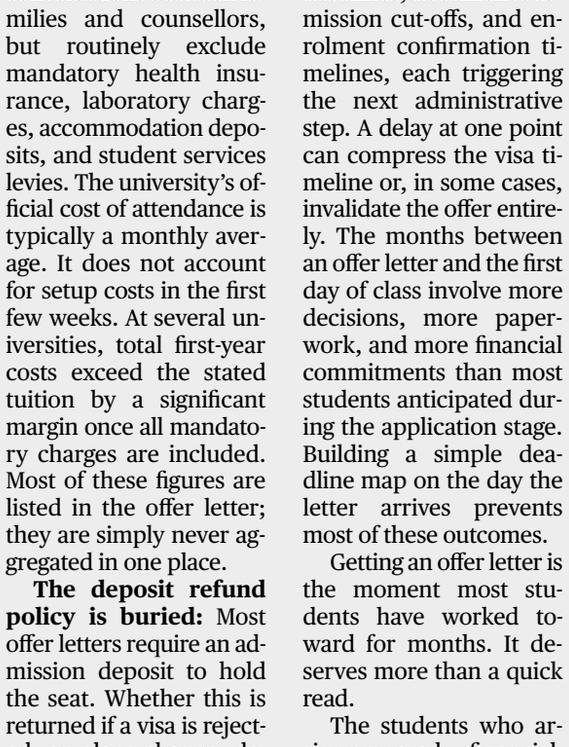
That student in the counsellor's office was not broken. The students walking onto campus this year are not weaker than those before them. They are differently prepared, shaped by a system that prized compliance over curiosity. Universities can keep treating that mismatch as the student's failing, or own it as their job. Because teaching students how to learn again is not remedial work at the edges of higher education. It is the thing the edges are built around.

The writer is Chief Learner and Director, Delhi Public School (DPS) Varanasi, Nashik, Lava Nagpur, Hinjawadi Pune, and the upcoming Pune East campus and co-founder, Equanimity Learning.

Beyond acceptance

Why students must scrutinise an international university's offer letter carefully

Vikash Agarwal



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The number of Indians studying abroad crossed 1.33 million in 2024, and shifting 2025-26 mobility patterns make scrutinising offers more important than ever. Yet one of the most consequential documents in the entire process routinely receives the least scrutiny: the offer letter itself.

For thousands of Indian students, an offer letter from an international university marks the culmination of months of preparation. This is the first binding document in what becomes a multi-year financial and academic relationship with a foreign institution. Patterns in how it is misread tend to cluster around the same five areas.

Conditional offers are not confirmations: A large proportion of offer letters issued to Indian students are conditional, contingent on English proficiency scores, final Class 12 transcripts, financial proof, or other prerequisites. A conditional offer can be revoked or cancelled if the student is unable to fulfil the stated requirements. Students who treat a conditional offer as admission secured have, in several cases, discovered weeks before intake that they are technically not enrolled. The condition clauses are typically listed in the middle, in the same formatting as everything else, which makes them easy to read past.

Scholarships rarely renew automatically: Merit-based aid, increasingly offered by institutions in the U.K. and Ireland to attract Indian applicants, frequently carries renewal conditions that do not appear in the headline offer. GPA thresholds, minimum credit loads, and restrictions on programme transfers are common. A scholarship worth ₹8-10 lakhs in annual relief can lapse after year one if a student changes specialisation or drops below the prescribed academic standing. The amount is visible in the offer letter; the conditions governing its continuation require a closer read of the attached terms.

The stated tuition fee is not the total cost: Tuition figures dominate conversations between families and counsellors, but routinely exclude mandatory health insurance, laboratory charges, accommodation deposits, and student services levies. The university's official cost of attendance is typically a monthly average. It does not account for setup costs in the first few weeks. At several universities, total first-year costs exceed the stated tuition by a significant margin once all mandatory charges are included. Most of these figures are listed in the offer letter; they are simply never aggregated in one place.

The deposit refund policy is buried: Most offer letters require an admission deposit to hold the seat. Whether this is returned if a visa is rejected, or plans change, depends entirely on the individual institution's policy. Terms vary considerably. Some universities treat the deposit as non-refundable the moment the offer is formally accepted, regardless of what follows. With students increasingly holding parallel applications at multiple destinations, losing a deposit due to a change of plans is a real and avoidable risk. The clause is always in the letter but not in the paragraph anyone reads first.

Deadlines are sequential, not independent: Offer letters carry multiple dates, acceptance windows, deposit deadlines, document submission cut-offs, and enrolment confirmation timelines, each triggering the next administrative step. A delay at one point can compress the visa timeline or, in some cases, invalidate the offer entirely. The months between an offer letter and the first day of class involve more decisions, more paperwork, and more financial commitments than most students anticipated during the application stage. Building a simple deadline map on the day the letter arrives prevents most of these outcomes.

Getting an offer letter is the moment most students have worked toward for months. It deserves more than a quick read.

The students who arrive prepared – financially, logistically, academically – are almost always the ones who treat that document as the beginning of their planning, not the end of it. The offer letter will not chase anyone down with a reminder. But everything it contains will eventually matter.

The writer is the founder, chairman, and managing director of Crizac Limited.



THINK
Aruna Sankaranarayanan

In the age of AI, you may think honing your writing is redundant. If you can get a bot to edit your work, why bother with sharpening your writing skills? While you may post a well-crafted piece on LinkedIn or submit a lucid essay, does the writing churned out by a bot express who you are? Do you see yourself reflected in the words?

Even as you use AI for various tasks, continue to cultivate your singular writing voice. Don't let efficiency trump authenticity. How you write shapes how you think, and how you think impacts who you are. If you don't want to surrender your thinking or sense of self to a bot, keep writing.

Power of the word

In Verb Your Enthusiasm, Pulitzer Prize winner Sarah Kaufman argues that you can transform your writing by wielding verbs wisely. Verbs are powerful as their implied movement stirs our minds and bodies. While you may write, *The man walks into the room,* see how the meaning of this sentence changes if you substitute '*walks*' with any one of these verbs: *ambles, bounces, creeps, dashes, shuffles*. Each verb elicits a different image of speed, style, energy and emotion. According to Kaufman, "deliberate verb choices" can "sharpen" your writing because verbs pack in so much meaning.



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Mind your words

How using the right verb can transform writing

It is critical to ponder or agonise over verb choices. Kaufman suggests "replacing vague verbs with specific ones." For example, in the sentence *She put the book down*, replace '*put*' with *slams, lays, drops, or slides*. Choose the verb that perfectly fits the context. Further, a "precise verb" can make adverbs redundant. Instead of *The lady unwrapped the gift furiously,* you may say, *The lady tore open the gift*.

Likewise, *Seema sipped wine* is preferable to *Seema drank wine slowly*. As most writers of fiction are advised to "show, not tell", precise verbs can invigorate prose by evoking the right action.

When it comes to reporting conversation, Kaufman advocates using 'says' or 'said', as the focus has to be on the character words. Using other verbs like *commands, yells, cries or pleads* can distract the reader from the content of the conversation.

Like many writing guides, Kaufman asks us to be circumspect while using the passive voice. Typically, the passive construction is used to "soft-pedal reality". For example, the statement, "Mistakes were made," absolves the subject by omitting them. Who made the mistake? Most often, using the active voice leads to crisper and clearer communication.

Keep it simple

Be and do verb forms are banal. Kaufman suggests replacing them with "verbs of action". Instead of *He was baking a cake, He baked a cake* lands better. She also cautions against using "fancy verbs" over "effective" ones. For example, 'use', 'explain', and 'improve' do a better job than 'utilise', 'elucidate', or 'ameliorate.' Vague 'generalities' like "giving 110%", "moving the needle", or "raising the bar" don't signify anything specific unless the writer offers details of what they mean.

You may also spice up your writing with verb-driven metaphors and similes. As metaphors convert abstract concepts into tangible things, employ verbs to invigorate different senses. Verbs may also rev up emotions and "deepen descriptions".

According to Kaufman, the perfect verb "clicks like a lock". To help you master the verb, she recommends reading sportswriters. Likewise, dance reviews may burst with verbs to capture the dynamism of a show. Keep your eyes and ears open for novel verbs. Unlike AI-generated prose, she urges you to jolt readers with "fresh verbs".

In an article in *The New York Times*, Bret Stephens says that, just as digital devices have caused a "decline of reading", AI is likely to have a similar impact on writing. Unlike speech, which can be uttered in haste, we assume that the written word is considered and coherent. Expend effort and cultivate your unique writing voice. Your older self will thank you for it.

The writer is visiting faculty, School of Education, Azim Premji University and the co-author of Bee-witched.

Payroll to prediction

Why Management institutes need to update their HR curriculum

Achal Khanna

When asked to describe HR, most people will think of paperwork, payroll, a disciplinary meeting nobody wants to be in. Today, that picture is no longer true. An HR person might spend the morning checking whether an AI hiring tool is quietly discriminating against candidates, the afternoon redesigning a leadership pipeline. The job has moved faster than the classrooms training people for it.

In global surveys and reports conducted across the world, many organisations point to AI, digital and data skills as their single biggest workforce constraint right now. Others were seriously short on Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) capability as well.

This is a problem showing up in graduates walking out of business schools with a syllabus that still treats HR as paperwork rather than strategy. So, what actually needs to change on campus?



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The changes

Start with data. HR professionals now need to read a dashboard, question what a model is telling them, and defend a call using numbers instead of gut feelings. This is different from memorising sections of labour law and it deserves its own paper, not one chapter buried inside an analytics elective nobody signs up for.

Next is AI. Learning to use an AI tool is the easy part and most students figure it out on their own. The harder skill is knowing when to trust what the tool says and when to push back. Interestingly, professionals who rate critical thinking as most important are not avoiding AI, but are using it the most. Comfort with and scepticism towards a tool are not opposites.

Skills-based thinking needs classroom time too, and this one gets overlooked a lot. Companies are drifting away from rigid job descriptions toward skills taxonomies and internal mobility. A graduate who can build and run a skills-based talent system, instead of just filling job-based ones, is already ahead of the HR departments he/she will join.

None of this replaces the human element. Leadership and people management still come up as the single biggest skill employers say they need. Managing a workforce that now spans five generations under one roof, being honest with people about decisions that affect their careers, and sitting through a hard conversation without flinching are no longer soft skills on the side. No dashboard is working out those tasks, and any new curriculum needs to step up to this ask in content and delivery.

ESG deserves a real seat in the curriculum, not the token compliance chapter it usually gets. A student who can connect workforce policy to a company's environmental and social commitments has an edge in the hiring room that most of their batch mates simply will not.

None of this calls for tearing down a two-year programme and starting over. It just asks institutes to treat HR the way the market already does: as a strategic, data-literate, technology-aware function that still runs on judgment and people skills.

Graduates who arrive with that mix will not need on-the-job catching up. Those who arrive knowing only compliance and payroll will spend the first year learning a job that changed long before they enrolled.

The writer is the CEO of Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM) Asia-Pacific (APAC) and Middle East and North Africa (MENA).